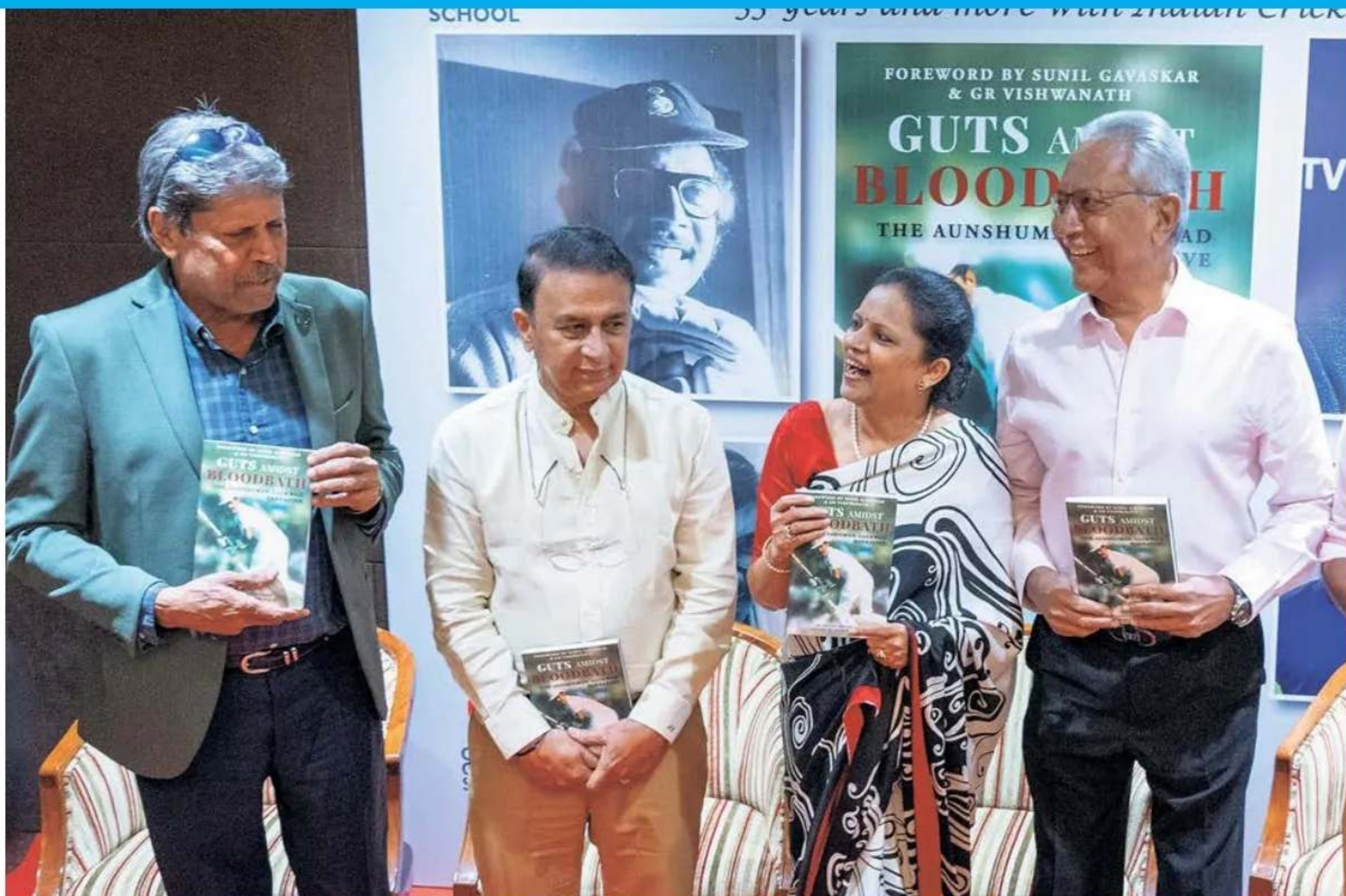




Friendship and memories: Former cricketers Kapil Dev and Sunil Gavaskar with Aunshuman Gaekwad and his wife at the launch of Gaekwad's book *Guts Amidst Bloodbath: The Aunshuman Gaekwad Narrative*. EMMANUAL YOGINI

views as a media expert. His honest analysis earned him respect in the industry.

My last two meetings with Gaekwad were in Mumbai — in May 2023, at his book launch at the Cricket Club of India, and two months later, at an event organised by my journalist friend Dwarkanath Sanzgiri to celebrate Tendulkar's 50th birthday.

A galaxy of cricketers turned up for his book launch. Kapil, Dilip Vengsarkar, Gavaskar, Roger Binny, Tendulkar, Zaheer Khan, Vishwanath, Karsan Ghavri, Abey Kuruvilla, Nayan Mongia, and Yajurvindra Singh lent their support to Gaekwad.

"He has given Indian cricket everything as a player, coach, administrator, selector — you name

it, and he has done it all. That he is not only liked by players from his time but also those who came after his time as a cricketer is a tribute to how well-liked Aunshu is," Gavaskar said. "He was my opening partner; we had some interesting times. Between the two of us, we never got each other run out. That's why we are on talking terms and can pull each other's legs."

Tendulkar recalled Gaekwad's preference for spicy food. "I remember during our 1998-99 tour to New Zealand, we went to a restaurant, and I said, 'Let's order pasta or chicken.' He said he does not like bland food at all. So Aunshu bhai asks the chef for the spiciest chilli sauce.

The chef says, 'Would you be able to handle it? It's extremely spicy.' He says, 'Make it as spicy as possible and get it.' The chef brought the sauce, which I tasted a little bit. It was so spicy that I could barely finish a quarter of a spoon with my entire meal. Aunshu bhai finished two bowls of the sauce. The chef couldn't believe it. That's when I realised it

wasn't just fiery bowling he could handle, but also the food."

Gaekwad appeared unwell in July. His tired look did not match his personality. Gaekwad was always a fit man, and only a routine check revealed the dreaded disease that was to consume him.

Gaekwad was advised to go to London for treatment but returned home disappointed. His long-time friend, Amarnath, visited Gaekwad and took it upon himself to raise funds for the treatment with help from Gavaskar, Sandeep Patil, and Kapil. Amarnath described Gaekwad as "a great batter, a dear friend, and a lovely human being."

Gaekwad experienced hurt from the cricketing community at various points. Still, his kind-hearted nature prevented him from holding any grudges, even against the man who nearly ended his life on the pitch. Gaekwad affectionately referred to Holding as "Mikey" and considered him a friend. That was Aunshuman Dattajirao Gaekwad — an unflinching batter and a trusted friend. He was 71.